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Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

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Section Title(S): The Joking Relationship

The jokes that are permitted among persons who have the joking relationship, and are avoided among those who do not, are sexual jokes and insults. Anyone may make jokes that are not sexually tinged. Persons who have the joking relationship constantly use it and enjoy it. Men accuse each other of having genital organs of excessive size or abnormal condition (castration or circumcision), or of being excessively preoccupied with sexual intercourse, unable to leave their wives long enough to go hunting. (Only a mad person would say that to a man unless he had the joking relationship with him, we were told.) We noticed that the !Kung do not call each other sons of bitches or base their insults in any way upon ancestry. Men accuse women with whom they may joke of being lazy, useless, slovenly, wanton, or ugly ("Your figure looks like a man's" [is as tall as a man's]). A man may accuse a woman of gadding about, visiting a great deal, and not being home when her husband wants her; or, worse, a man might accuse a woman of eating all the plant food she gathers and bringing nothing home to her family. The women retaliate, perhaps accusing the men of being worthy only of castration or of unfaithful wives. Frequently a man joking with a woman calls her "my wife." The implication is that they have sexual relations together; the !Kung find this pretense very funny. A boy might say "my wife" or "I am going to marry you" to a girl with whom he could joke, implying that they had had or would have sexual relations; but it would be considered neither proper nor funny to say such a thing to a very young girl, regardless of whether the boy and girl had the joking relationship.

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To make blatantly insulting jokes with old people is not proper. The deference due to aged persons is expressed in the joking relationship by a moderate tone, and the joking relationship between an old person and a considerably younger one, especially between grandparents and grandchildren, becomes a cozy, friendly intimacy without the sexual emphasis.

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Laughter, often uproarious, follows the jokes. A particularly telling sally brings out shrieks and howls. Everyone around hears the jokes and joins in the laughter. People are forbidden to address jokes to those with whom they do not have the joking relationship, but they are not forbidden to laugh at jokes addressed to those persons by others.

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There may be occasions when someone takes advantage of the joking relationship to vent his animosity and to hurt someone in anger. I  206 believe that. Gao Beard and /Ti!kay have been known to give a bitter flavor to their joking. But this, the !Kung said, is not the custom. When people are quarreling, they said, they do not use the joking words.

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